DBQ Point Guide 2: Contextualization

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What the rubric requires

The contextualization point (Row B, 1 pt) goes to an accurate *description* of broader events, developments, or processes before, during, or after the prompt's time frame that bear on its topic.

Three tests decide it:

1. **Relevant.** The context has to connect to the prompt's topic, not just its era. "The Spanish had colonies in Latin America" was rejected for a slavery prompt.
2. **Described, not named.** "This point is not awarded for merely a phrase or reference." One accurate sentence that explains what happened clears the bar; a label ("the Cold War," "gold, god, and glory") does not.
3. **Accurate.** Historically wrong context earns nothing, for example "Most colonists fought in the American Revolution to protect their slaves from British abolitionists."

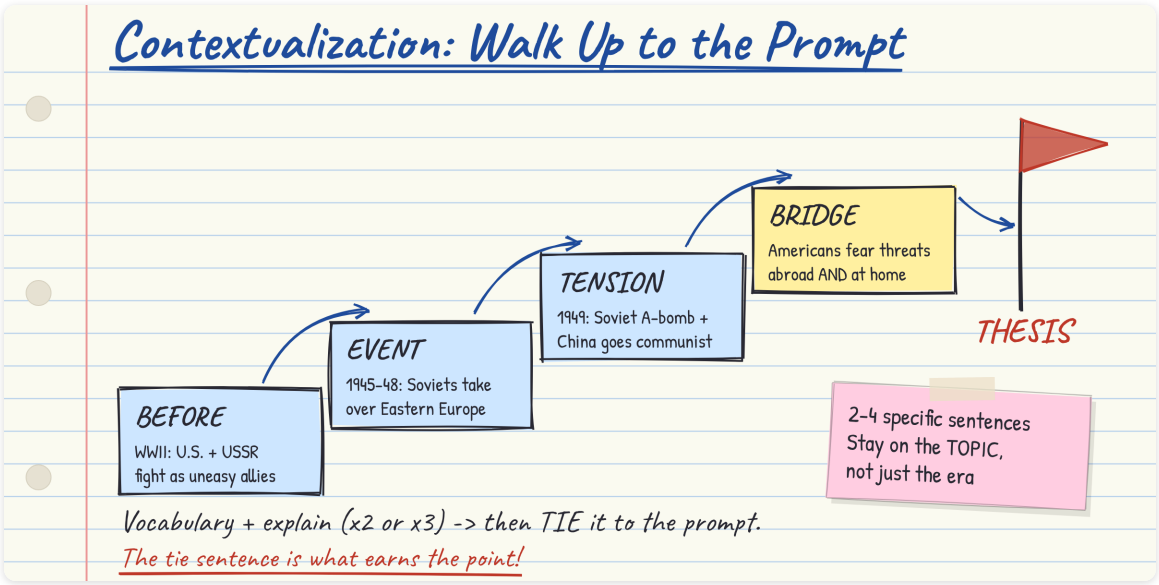
Two rules trip students up:

- **It can appear anywhere.** 2024 Set 2 Sample 1B earned the point in its *final* paragraph by describing post-1945 Cold War civil-defense fears.
- **It can't be reused.** Whatever earns contextualization can't also earn Evidence Beyond the Documents (Guide 4).

This is the most commonly lost early point in the samples: 5 of the 6 lowest-scoring essays (Sample 1C in each set) missed it, mostly by skipping it or writing one vague line.

The foolproof formula

Write contextualization as the first 3–4 sentences of the introduction, using a **Before → Event → Tension → Bridge** frame:



1. **Before.** Name a specific development from the 10–30 years before the prompt's start date. Use a name and a date, not "back then."
2. **Event.** Describe what happened in one full sentence: who did what, and what changed.
3. **Tension.** Explain the problem or pressure it created that relates to the prompt's topic.
4. **Bridge.** Connect that pressure to the prompt's start date. The thesis comes right after.

> Frame: "Before [start year], [specific development] [did what]. This [created problem/pressure related to topic]. As a result, by [start year], Americans [faced/debated/feared] [topic of prompt]."

Rules to drill:

- **Use a different event than your outside evidence.** Context lives *outside* the argument (usually before the time frame); outside evidence lives *inside* it.
- **Two or three sentences minimum.** The minimally acceptable College Board examples are a single sentence, but students who write three never fall below the bar.
- **Stay on topic, not just on era.** The test: "Does this help explain *why* the prompt's topic mattered at that moment?"

Cold War DBQ model (written for this guide):

> "During the Second World War the United States and the Soviet Union fought as uneasy allies, but by 1945 Soviet armies occupied Eastern Europe and Stalin installed communist governments there. In 1949 the Soviets tested an atomic bomb and communists won the Chinese Civil War, ending America's nuclear monopoly and making communism look like it was spreading. These shocks convinced many Americans that the nation faced a threat both abroad and at home."

Examples that earned the point

Source	What the student wrote	Why it earned the point
2024 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7)	Described the European crisis that led to WWI, including the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand and the Bolshevik Revolution.	Specific events, fully described, that explain where 1917–1945 fears came from. Commentary: “thoroughly describes.”
2025 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	Traced government's economic role from late-1800s laissez-faire to the Progressive Era and WWI.	Shows the “before” state the prompt's change is measured against.
2025 Set 1, Sample 1B (score 5)	Described “risky banking practices” and a growing consumer culture that contributed to the Great Depression.	Explains the pressure that pushed the government into the economy in 1932.
2023 Set 2, Sample 1A (score 7)	Connected the Civil War, emancipation, and the 13th Amendment to the call for more rights.	Three linked developments tied directly to citizenship.
2024 Set 1, Sample 1A (score 7)	Described the American Revolution, the ban on the international slave trade, and “tensions between abolitionists and slaveholders.”	Relevant to slavery, not just to the era.
2024 Set 2, Sample 1C (score 3)	Described the First and Second Red Scares, domino theory, and the Vietnam War.	Context that comes *after* the time frame counts. A 3-point essay still earned it.
2024 Set 2, Sample 1B (score 5)	In the **final paragraph**, described post-1945 Cold War fears and the “Bert the Turtle” civil-defense campaign.	Location doesn't matter; it can be in the conclusion.

Minimally acceptable (College Board's own examples):

- “The stock market crashed, causing lots of unemployment.” (2025)
- “American colonists had a revolution but still kept slavery.” (2024)
- “The United States tried to limit immigration from China with the Chinese Exclusion Act.” (2024)

Each is one sentence, but each *describes* something (a cause and effect or a contradiction), not just a label.

Examples that did not earn the point

Failure type	Example	Why it fails
Passing phrase	2024 Set 1, Sample 1C: “gold, god, and glory leading to a new nation”	A slogan, not a description. Commentary: “just a passing phrase or reference.”
Too vague	2025 Set 2, Sample 1B: “American society has gone through a lot” and “made steps to better themselves”; “onward was a time of war”	No specific event, development, or process named.
Too vague	2025 Set 2, Sample 1C: the United States was “growing and expanding”	True of almost any era; describes nothing.
Not attempted	2023 Sets 1 and 2, 2025 Set 1, Sample 1C	Introduction jumps straight to the thesis. The most common way to lose the point.
Era but not topic	“During the Progressive Era the government introduced many reforms like food safety.” (2024, threats prompt)	Accurate, but unrelated to beliefs about threats.
Overgeneralized	“There were a lot of wars between 1917 and 1945.” (2024) / “The government was very active in people's lives during the time period.” (2025)	A general remark about the time period, not a development.
Inaccurate	“Before the Civil War, immigrants were not allowed to become citizens.” (2023)	Historically false context earns nothing.

Cold War non-examples (written for this guide):

- “The Cold War started after World War II.” A label with a date; nothing described.
- “In 1776 America declared independence and believed in freedom.” Accurate, but too distant and not connected to Cold War fears.

Expert tips (Heimler's History)

Heimler's advice matches the rubric and adds two concrete habits (Stop MISSING the CONTEXTUALIZATION Point, 2023; THREE Secrets, 2024):

- **Length:** 2–4 content-rich sentences. College Board examples show one sentence can earn it, so more than four wastes exam time (How to WRITE DBQs Faster).
- **How far back:** the immediate context, roughly 50–100 years before the prompt and "closer to 50 than 100" for APUSH.
- **Match the category, not just the era.** The two biggest mistakes he sees as a reader are context unrelated to the prompt's category and context that isn't specific. For a Progressive Era prompt, students reached back to Manifest Destiny and Reconstruction, which was "largely irrelevant" (Top 5 MISTAKES from the AP Readers).
- **Show, don't tell.** "Before 1900 there was a lot of social tension" tells. Naming southern segregation and the Exoduster migration shows.

His formula: Vocabulary → Explain → Tie. Name a term and explain it, two or three times, then write one sentence tying it all to the thesis topic ("This demonstrates that…"). He calls the tie sentence "crucial for earning the point." It matches the Bridge step in the formula above.

Rubric note: the rubric allows context from before, during, *or after* the time frame; Heimler's "go back in time" advice is just the simplest route. 2024 Set 2 Sample 1B earned the point with post-1945 context in its conclusion.

Grader checklist

Any "no" means 0 points.

1. Does the essay (anywhere) describe a specific event, development, or process outside the core of the argument?
2. Is it more than a phrase: does it say what happened, not just name it?
3. Is it accurate?
4. Is it relevant to the prompt's *topic*, not just its era?
5. Is it a different piece of evidence from the one credited for Evidence Beyond the Documents?

Feedback stems for students

- Earned: "Your context earns the point by explaining how [event] led to [pressure] before [start year]."
- Not earned (vague): "Name a specific event before [start year] and explain in 2–3 sentences how it set up [topic]."
- Not earned (missing): "Start your introduction with what was happening *before* the prompt's dates."